

resignation. On the eve of the Parliament session, Sonia Gandhi summoned a meeting of her core group, Ahmed Patel, A.K. Antony, P. Chidambaram and Pranab Mukherjee to discuss floor strategy. Later, Mukherjee summoned Tharoor for a late night meeting—and a dressing down. He has asked the junior minister to explain both his connection to Sunanda and the Kochi franchise. This incidentally was not the first time that Tharoor has been ticked off by Mukherjee who earlier pulled him up for his five-star lifestyle. The prime minister, who is reported to have a soft corner for Tharoor, too has promised to look into the matter after his return to India.

However, hasty executions have not been the hallmark of the Sonia-Manmohan leadership unless the situation becomes politically untenable. Take the example of Natwar Singh, another erudite Stephanian known for his proximity to 10 Janpath. When he was implicated in the Volcker report in 2005, at first he was merely stripped of his portfolio and remained a cabinet minister. It was only a month later, after the charges against him became impossible to refute that he was removed from the cabinet. Similarly in Tharoor's case, a Congress general secretary pointed out "he will be removed if charges of corruption or misuse of public office are proved against him".

In the meantime, Tharoor has moved in for some damage control of his own. His close friend Sunanda has reacted by denying that she is a proxy for Tharoor. And his trusted aide Jacob Joseph has launched a counter attack on Modi. Yet, what most of Tharoor's Congress colleagues want to know is how deep the Sunanda-Tharoor link is. Because, as a Congress general secretary pointed out, "having first said that he got no monetary gain from lobbying for the IPL, he cannot now be seen to access this equity in dowry".

New Delhi's latest couple-in-controversy first met in Dubai, where Sunanda, a Canadian passport-holder was working for Tecom, a real estate advisory company promoted by the Dubai Government. At that time,

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"My own business interests and assets are substantial. Efforts to besmirch Tharoor by presenting me as a proxy for him are personally insulting for me as a woman and as a friend. I have a respectable and successful career."

**SUNANDA PUSHKAR,
KOCHI IPL TEAM
STAKEHOLDER**

"I have neither invested nor received a rupee for my mentorship of the team. Whatever my personal relationships with any of the consortium members, I do not intend to benefit from the team financially."

**SHASHI
THAROOR,
UNION MINISTER**

PTI PHOTO BY KAMAL SINGH



**THE LATEST THAROOR
CONTROVERSY HAS EMBARRASSED
UPA CHAIRPERSON SONIA GANDHI**

Tharoor was the Chairman of Afras, based in Dubai, before assuming his present job. According to a Dubai-based former business associate of Sunanda's, she had a reputation of socialising with "big honchos"—industrialists, politicians and sheikhs—and Tharoor clearly matched the profile.

Soon after when Tharoor shifted to his new job, Sunanda took over the role of hostess at parties at the minister's official residence. She even accompanied him to an official trip to the North East organised by the Foreign Ministry's public diplomacy division. That Tharoor manages the Gulf portfolio in the foreign office and Sunanda works for a Dubai government company with unparalleled access to the minister does raise some questions of propriety.

However, it was at Union minister Jitin Prasada's wedding in February